of our only moviehouse with William S. Hart and Tom Mix galloping over the prairie or having my eyes turned misty by the cinematic perils that befell Mary Pickford and Pearl White. And when I was ten or eleven, one of my mother's sisters came to Dixon for a visit and our whole family went out to a silent movie. I don't remember its name, but it featured the adventures of a freckle-faced young boy and I enjoyed it a lot. Afterward, I overheard my aunt talking to my mother about this young star and saying she thought I had the potential to become a child actor. "If he was mine," she said, "I'd take him to Hollywood if I had to walk all the way."

Her remark didn't plant any visions in me—or Nelle—of rushing off to Hollywood. But it did make me feel good and from then on, whenever I went to a movie featuring a young boy, I fantasized about how much fun it would be to act out a part in a movie.

By my senior year at Eureka, my secret dream to be an actor was firmly planted, but I knew that in the middle of Illinois in 1932, I couldn't go around saying, "I want to be an actor."

To say I wanted to be a movie star would have been as eccentric as saying I wanted to go to the moon. Hollywood and Broadway were at least as remote from Dixon as the moon was in 1932. If I *had* told anyone I was setting out to be a movie star, they'd have carted me off to an institution.

But I had an idea. Broadway and Hollywood were a long way from Dixon, but not Chicago, the nation's hub of radio broadcasting.

In those days, commercial broadcasting was beginning to grab the hearts of America. When "Amos and Andy" came on the air, the whole world stopped: If you were at a movie theater, they'd shut off the projector, turn on the lights, and a radio set would be placed on the stage while everybody